Syllabus MA Seminar: Gender inequality and the labour market

September 2024

1 Course description

In recent times, economists have turned their focus to the differences between women and men in the labour market. This growing field reached a milestone last year when Claudia Goldin[1] received the Nobel Prize "for having advanced our understanding of women's labor market outcomes".

The behaviour of women in the labour market has important consequences for the economy overall. Hsieh et al (2019)[2] estimate that the improved labour market access for women generated 20-40% of economic growth between 1960 and 2010, highlighting the importance of breaking down barriers to access. The gender gap in earnings has narrowed substantially over time, but still persists. Women continue to shoulder the burden of childcare and household work, generating large earnings losses, yet studies have been unable to find effective remedies to increase gender equality.

In this MA seminar, students have the opportunity to study the phenomenon of gender gaps in depth. We begin with general evidence on gender gaps and their evolution over time. The rest of the seminar deals with possible reasons for persistent gender gaps in the labour market. In the past, unequal sharing of care and household work was understood as the main reason for gender gaps in participation and earnings. Nowadays, a major contributor to the gender gap in earnings lies in the child penalty, which has received extensive scrutiny over the last years. However, efforts to ameliorate the child penalty have proven elusive. A possible reason lies in the influence of social norms and non-pecuniary incentives. We also consider discrimination against women in the labour market. We end with a novel research field that has only arisen in the last two years, which considers the effects of violence against women at work.

The goal of this seminar is threefold. Firstly, students will familiarise themselves

[1] Who also holds an honorary doctorate from the University of Zurich

[2] Hsieh, C. T., Hurst, E., Jones, C. I., & Klenow, P. J. (2019). The allocation of talent and US economic growth. Econometrica, 87(5), 1439-1474.

with the latest research in this area. Secondly, they will learn about different empirical strategies, many of which this literature has innovated or adapted from the standard strategies. Finally, students will be encouraged to sharpen their research skills by identifying issues in methodology and potential avenues for future research.

2 Course structure

This course will start with an introductory session that provides an overview of the topics and the links between them. Students will then prepare a presentation on one paper and act as discussant for a second.

Students will have 25 minutes to present a paper from the provided list. The presentation should include:

- An introduction to the broader topic
- The research question and how it connects to the broader topic at hand
- The methodology
- The main findings
- The implications for public policy

Students will prepare a 10 minute discussion of a paper different from the paper they present. The discussion should very briefly summarize the methodology and main findings of the discussed paper and highlight possible caveats and extensions of the paper.

Students will write a final paper on the topic. This should include:

- An introduction to the topic
- A description of how the papers contribute to that topic
- A discussion of the limitations of the papers
- Avenues for future research

Students should try to link together the papers on the topic in their final paper. Students are also free to draw on additional papers that are not included on the reading list. The final paper should be 4-6 pages using 1" margins and 12-pt font.

The final grade will be based on a weighted average of the presentation (30%), the discussion and participation in the seminar discussions (20%), and the final paper (50%).

3 Reading list

3.1 Gender gaps

Overview:

Goldin, C. (2014). A grand gender convergence: Its last chapter. American Economic Review, 104(4), 1091-1119.

Papers for presentation & discussion:

Brenøe, A. A., & Zölitz, U. (2020). Exposure to more female peers widens the gender gap in STEM participation. Journal of Labor Economics, 38(4), 1009-1054.

Cook, C., Diamond, R., Hall, J. V., List, J. A., & Oyer, P. (2021). The gender earnings gap in the gig economy: Evidence from over a million rideshare drivers. The Review of Economic Studies, 88(5), 2210-2238.

Mulligan, C. B., & Rubinstein, Y. (2008). Selection, investment, and women's relative wages over time. The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 123(3), 1061-1110.

Olivetti, C., & Petrongolo, B. (2008). Unequal pay or unequal employment? A cross-country analysis of gender gaps. Journal of Labor Economics, 26(4), 621-654.

Additional readings:

Buser, T., Niederle, M., & Oosterbeek, H. (2014). Gender, competitiveness, and career choices. The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 129(3), 1409-1447.

3.2 Household economics

Overview:

Becker, G. S. (1985). Human capital, effort, and the sexual division of labor. Journal of Labor Economics, 3(1, Part 2), S33-S58.

Duflo, E. (2012). Women empowerment and economic development. Journal of Economic Literature, 50(4), 1051-1079.

Papers for presentation & discussion:

Adams-Prassl, A., Boneva, T., Golin, M., & Rauh, C. (2020). Inequality in the impact of the coronavirus shock: Evidence from real-time surveys. Journal of Public Economics, 189, 104245.

Adams-Prassl, A., Hara, K., Milland, K., & Callison-Burch, C. (2023). The gender wage gap in an online labor market: The cost of interruptions. Review of Economics and Statistics, 1-23.

Hupkau, C., & Petrongolo, B. (2020). Work, care and gender during the COVID-19 crisis. Fiscal Studies, 41(3), 623-651.

Guryan, J., Hurst, E., & Kearney, M. (2008). Parental education and parental time with children. Journal of Economic Perspectives, 22(3), 23-46.

Additional readings:

Grosjean, P., & Khattar, R. (2019). It's raining men! Hallelujah? The long-run consequences of male-biased sex ratios. The Review of Economic Studies, 86(2), 723-754.

3.3 The child penalty

Overview:

Kleven, H., Landais, C., & Søgaard, J. E. (2019). Children and gender inequality: Evidence from Denmark. American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, 11(4), 181-209.

Kleven, H., Landais, C., Posch, J., Steinhauer, A., & Zweimüller, J. (2019, May). Child penalties across countries: Evidence and explanations. In AEA Papers and Proceedings (Vol. 109, pp. 122-126). American Economic Association.

Papers for presentation & discussion:

Adda, J., Dustmann, C., & Stevens, K. (2017). The career costs of children. Journal of Political Economy, 125(2), 293-337.

Andresen, M. E., & Nix, E. (2022). What causes the child penalty? Evidence from adopting and same-sex couples. Journal of Labor Economics, 40(4), 971-1004.

Havnes, T., & Mogstad, M. (2011). Money for nothing? Universal child care and maternal employment. Journal of Public Economics, 95(11-12), 1455-1465.

Kleven, H., Landais, C., Posch, J., Steinhauer, A., & Zweimüller, J. (2024). Do family policies reduce gender inequality? Evidence from 60 years of policy experimentation. American Economic Journal: Economic Policy, 16(2), 110-149.

Additional readings:

Lundborg, P., Plug, E., & Rasmussen, A. W. (2024). Is there really a child penalty in the long run? New evidence from IVF treatments.

3.4 Gender norms

Overview:

Bertrand, M. (2020, May). Gender in the twenty-first century. AEA Papers and Proceedings, 110, 1-24.

Papers for presentation & discussion:

Bertrand, M., Kamenica, E., & Pan, J. (2015). Gender identity and relative income within households. The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 130(2), 571-614.

Bursztyn, L., Fujiwara, T., & Pallais, A. (2017). "'Acting wife': Marriage market incentives and labor market investments." American Economic Review, 107(11), 3288-3319.

Bursztyn, L., González, A. L., & Yanagizawa-Drott, D. (2020). Misperceived social norms: Women working outside the home in Saudi Arabia. American Economic Review, 110(10), 2997-3029.

Field, E., Pande, R., Rigol, N., Schaner, S., & Troyer Moore, C. (2021). On her own account: How strengthening women's financial control impacts labor supply and gender norms. American Economic Review, 111(7), 2342-2375.

Additional readings:

Alesina, A., Giuliano, P., & Nunn, N. (2013). On the origins of gender roles: Women and the plough. The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 128(2), 469-530.

Beaman, L., Duflo, E., Pande, R., & Topalova, P. (2012). Female leadership raises aspirations and educational attainment for girls: A policy experiment in India. Science, 335(6068), 582-586.

3.5 Gender discrimination

Overview: Bertrand, M., Chugh, D., & Mullainathan, S. (2005). Implicit discrimination. American Economic Review, 95(2), 94-98.

Papers for presentation & discussion:

Becker, S. O., Fernandes, A., & Weichselbaumer, D. (2019). Discrimination in hiring based on potential and realized fertility: Evidence from a large-scale field experiment. Labour Economics, 59, 139-152.

Bohren, J. A., Haggag, K., Imas, A., & Pope, D. G. (2023). Inaccurate statistical discrimination: An identification problem. Review of Economics and Statistics, 1-45.

Goldin, C., & Rouse, C. (2000). Orchestrating impartiality: The impact of "blind" auditions on female musicians. American Economic Review, 90(4), 715-741.

Heyman, F., Svaleryd, H., & Vlachos, J. (2013). Competition, takeovers, and gender discrimination. ILR Review, 66(2), 409-432.

Additional readings:

Schaerer, M., Du Plessis, C., Nguyen, M. H. B., Van Aert, R. C., Tiokhin, L., Lakens, D., Clemente, E. G., Pfeiffer, T., Dreber, A., Johannesson, M., Clark,

C. J., & Uhlmann, E. L. (2023). On the trajectory of discrimination: A meta-analysis and forecasting survey capturing 44 years of field experiments on gender and hiring decisions. Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 179, 104280. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.obhdp.2023.104280

3.6 Gender-based violence

Overview: Aizer, A. (2010). The gender wage gap and domestic violence. American Economic Review, 100(4), 1847-1859.

Papers for presentation & discussion:

Adams, A., Huttunen, K., Nix, E., & Zhang, N. (2024). The Dynamics of Abusive Relationships. The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 1-46.

Adams-Prassl, A., Huttunen, K., Nix, E., & Zhang, N. (2024). Violence against women at work. The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 139(2), 937-991.

Dahl, G. B., & Knepper, M. M. (2021). Why is workplace sexual harassment underreported? The value of outside options amid the threat of retaliation. National Bureau of Economic Research WP 29248, 1-38.

Folke, O., & Rickne, J. (2022). Sexual harassment and gender inequality in the labor market. The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 137(4), 2163-2212.

Additional readings:

Antecol, H., & Cobb-Clark, D. (2006). The sexual harassment of female active-duty personnel: Effects on job satisfaction and intentions to remain in the military. Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization, 61(1), 55-80.

Egan, M., Matvos, G., & Seru, A. (2022). When Harry fired Sally: The double standard in punishing misconduct. Journal of Political Economy, 130(5), 1184-1248.

Hersch, J. (2011). Compensating differentials for sexual harassment. American Economic Review, 101(3), 630-634.